

all about winning. The alpha male is the leader, the hero, the winner. It's hard to resist wanting to be the alpha investor. The personality is everywhere. He's the big man on campus. He's got the big wheels and the big biceps when he is young. When he's older, he's got the big bank account.

In business, he wants to win—and win big. And fast. He dreams of starting a company or a hedge fund, making a big score, and retiring before he is 40. How? By outperforming his peers, by winning.

In investments, he likes systems, secrets, hot tips, new technology—anything that will help him make money fast. He's a winner in whatever he does. And he keeps score!

But long-term family investing is a different matter. We don't care about winning. We don't care about finding the stock that doubles, triples, or goes to the moon. We don't want to win. Instead, we want to succeed. Right here on Planet Earth.

Success means not getting distracted by short-term opportunities. It means avoiding getting involved in extraneous investments, businesses, gambles, projects—even when it looks as if you could win at them. It means seeing targets of opportunities and ignoring them. It means having a strategy that can take you where you want to go, and sticking with it, even when it seems that it might be much more fun—and more rewarding—to do something else. Our aim is not to get more profit than the next fellow. It's not about being right while others are wrong. And it's not even about having more money in our account at the end of the month or the end of the year.

It's success we're after, not victory. And success for the family beta investor means taking the time to listen to the market's story. Giving it time to tell its story. Letting it explain itself before you take a major position.

ALPHA MATTERS, TOO

There are only three main variables:

- Your choice of beta—your asset allocations.
- The number of years you are invested.